

Psalms 47

Clap Your Hands

O clap your hands, all ye people
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 O clap your hands, all ye people; shout unto God with the voice of triumph.
- 2 For the LORD most high is terrible; he is a great King over all the earth.
- 3 He shall subdue the people under us, and the nations under our feet.
- 4 He shall choose our inheritance for us, the excellency of Jacob whom he loved. Selah.
- 5 God is gone up with a shout, the LORD with the sound of a trumpet.
- 6 Sing praises to God, sing praises: sing praises unto our King, sing praises.
- 7 For God is the King of all the earth: sing ye praises with understanding.
- 8 God reigneth over the heathen: God sitteth upon the throne of his holiness.
- 9 The princes of the people are gathered together, even the people of the God of Abraham: for the shields of the earth belong unto God: he is greatly exalted.

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 47 is an enthronement hymn calling all peoples—not Israel alone—to celebrate God as King over the whole earth, who subdues nations and ascends His throne amid shouting and trumpet blast. The church has long read it as anticipating Christ’s ascension and universal reign, while Jewish tradition connects its kingship theme to the celebration of Rosh Hashanah. Its energy is unrestrained joy rather than solemn petition, a call to loud, physical praise.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

Clap your hands, all peoples; shout to God with a voice of triumph, for the Lord most high is terrible (awesome), King over all the earth. He subdues peoples under us and nations under our feet, choosing our inheritance for us—“the excellency of Jacob, whom he loved.”

Verse 5-7

God has gone up with a shout, the Lord with the sound of a trumpet. Sing praises to God, sing praises to our King, for God is King of all the earth—sing praises with understanding, not mere noise.

Verse 8-9

God reigns over the heathen and sits upon the throne of His holiness; the princes of the peoples are gathered together with the people of the God of Abraham, for the shields (rulers) of the earth belong to God, who is greatly exalted.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Praise here is deliberately physical, loud, and universal—an invitation extended to all nations, not a private or quiet devotion. God’s kingship is not merely spiritual sentiment; it actively subdues real nations and holds real authority over every ruler on earth.

Application for life today.

Let your praise be more physically expressive this week—claps, shouts, or simply louder singing—rather than only internal reflection. Consider that God’s kingship extends over every current national and political power, however dominant they seem; pray this psalm over headlines that trouble you. Practice “sing praises with understanding” (v. 7): choose one truth about God’s reign to think through carefully before or while you worship.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What would more physically expressive praise look like for you personally, and what holds you back from it?

2. How does knowing God is “King over all the earth” (v. 2) change how you pray about a current national or global concern?

3. What is one truth about God’s reign you want to “sing... with understanding” rather than just repeat by habit?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).